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Joshua Nations

Obadiah

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Obadiah

A. Overview and Summary. Obadiah is the shortest book in the Old Testament, consisting of 21 verses. We know nothing of Obadiah, the prophet. He wrote shortly after the destruction of Jerusalem by the Babylonians in 586 BC. It is a condemnation of Edom, located in present day Jordan. The Edomites are descendants of Esau while Israelites are descendants of Jacob. Jacob and Esau struggled in the womb and the two nations have been struggling ever since. King Herod, in the New Testament, was an Edomite who attempted to kill the baby Jesus.

B. Obadiah makes note of Edom dwelling in clefts of the rocks: “The pride of your heart has deceived you, you who live in the clefts of the rock, in your lofty dwelling, who say in your heart, ‘Who will bring me down to the ground?’” (Vs. 3). This could be a reference to the city of Petra, a sandstone location in southern Jordan. It is reached only by a ¾-mile narrow gorge, which made it easily defensible. The Edomites inhabited Petra during the iron age after the death of King Solomon.

C. Obadiah writes to condemn the Edomites who rejoiced when the Babylonians destroyed Jerusalem: “On the day that you stood aloof, on the day that strangers carried off his wealth and foreigners entered his gates and cast lots for Jerusalem, you were like one of them” (Vs. 11). They looted Jerusalem and God pronounced His judgement upon them: “Because of the violence done to your brother Jacob, shame shall cover you, and you shall be cut off forever” (Vs. 10).

D. Obadiah pronounces judgement upon the nations on the day of the Lord: “For the day of the LORD is near upon all the nations. As you have done, it shall be done to you; your deeds shall return on your own head. For as you have drunk on my holy mountain, so all the nations shall drink continually; they shall drink and swallow, and shall be as though they had never been” (Vs.15).

E. The book closes with a prophecy of the restoration of Israel under the Messiah: “The exiles of this host of the people of Israel shall possess the land of the Canaanites as far as Zarephath, and the exiles of Jerusalem who are in Sepharad shall possess the cities of the Negeb. Saviors shall go up to Mount Zion to rule Mount Esau, and the kingdom shall be the LORD’s” (Vs. 20-21).

F. Discussion, Application and Passing it on.

1. Edom's sin was pride and an unwillingness to assist Israel. Pride is often the cause of sin. Are you prideful? What does the Scripture tell you to do?
2. The word "saviors" in verse 21 is a reference to apostles who preach the gospel in these last days. An apostle is simply a "sent one". Are you equipped to "be sent" to share the gospel with your unsaved family, friends, neighbors and co-workers? If not, how can you be equipped to be ready to do so?

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)